4

THE PRIME MINISTER'S OFFICE (PMO) CALLED VIJAY KARAN BACK after five days in Colombo. The CBI head stopped in Madras on his way back to Delhi. Raju, Kanth, Sri Kumar, Verma and Ragothaman were present at the airport for a closed-door meeting with him. Sources in Colombo had already confirmed that the kurta-pyjama-clad man had only one eye and his name was Packiaraj, one of his many aliases. Karan briefed his officers on everything he had been able to gather in Colombo, and they, in turn, reported their progress in detail. There was no new information except what the SIT had already learnt about the kurta-pyjama man—that he was an LTTE operative who was one-eyed and known as Sivaraja Master with possible aliases such as Sivarasan, Sivarajan and Packiaraj. But that was yet to be confirmed. The flight was waiting for Karan as the rest of the passengers were already on board.

After reaching home, Karan was told that Cabinet Secretary Naresh Chandra had called twice. He promptly returned Chandra's call. He came on the line and said he was expecting Karan to reach his office straight from the airport. The CBI chief had not had a bath for the past two days and requested time for a quick shower. Chandra noted that Karan had better hurry since the Prime Minister was losing patience.

When Karan entered the cabinet secretary's room, the home secretary and the heads of IB and R&AW were already there. Karan took them through the progress made by the SIT until then and how it was suspecting the LTTE to be behind the assassination. His debriefing was backed by evidence and his latest findings on the kurta-pyjama-clad man. Karan emphasized that the man from Haribabu's first photograph had been identified by independent sources from both Tamil Nadu and Colombo,